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IT'S A BUSY Saturday afternoon at Jio World Drive, Mumbai's latest shopping destination, where global luxury and bridge-to-luxury brands share space with Indian lifestyle brands. Opened last year, the 17.5-acre mall owned by Reliance Retail is the ideal destination for the over 60 global brands that Reliance Brands Limited (RBL) has a tie-up with, including Coach, Bally, Tumi, Michael Kors, Kate Spade, etc. Here we meet 23-year-old Advait Rane, who has just started working with a leading multinational firm, and is looking for a laptop bag. "My bag's probably more expensive than the laptop, but the company provides the laptop," laughs Rane, as he pays ₹58,000 for a Coach laptop bag. He is familiar with the brand as his parents gifted him a Coach wallet on his 18th birthday. He had done his research online and knew what he wanted. At the store, he just wanted to double check that the bag wasn't too heavy as he often needed to carry it around.

At Delhi's DLF Emporio mall, weekend footfalls have increased from an average 12,000 during pre-Covid-19 times to nearly 18,000 now. The mall, considered the mecca for luxury retail in Delhi, houses brands such as Cartier, Dior, Bvlgari, Gucci, Versace, etc. Pushpa Bector, Executive Director of DLF Retail, says international brands have seen sales increase by 60-70 per cent from pre-Covid-19 levels at the mall. "Once Indians stopped travelling abroad during Covid-19, they discovered the luxury brands in India. And now, they are continuing to shop here even with international travel having opened up," says Bector.

In the mall, you can't help but notice the number of millennials and GenZ. "Millennials are consuming luxury without feeling guilty unlike the previous generation, which had to save for luxury," says Bector. Unlike Gen X, which was first introduced to luxury two decades ago when Louis Vuitton entered India in 2002, GenZ (born between 1995 and 2009) has grown up seeing luxury brands around them. Gucci, LV, Michael Kors, etc., are names that even many teenagers are familiar with. "GenZ and Gen Alpha (born between 2010 and 2024) are known to be quite active on social media platforms and are also very outgoing and aspirational. With a firm belief in the statement 'You Only Live Once', they are looking to experiment with personal luxury products that are

targeted towards their age group and gender," says Anul Sareen, Project Manager at Euromonitor International, a market research provider. As per data from Euromonitor International, the Indian luxury goods market, which comprises personal luxury, fine wines and spirits, luxury automobiles and experiential luxury, was worth ₹56,764 crore in 2019. It fell to ₹32,789 crore in 2020 and has now bounced back to ₹46,098 crore in 2022. It is likely to cross ₹50,000 crore in 2024.

So, what's fuelling the market? "Thanks to roaring stock markets and the start-up boom, India is one of the fastest-growing HNWI (high net-worth individuals) markets in the world. This is causing rapid expansion of the ultra-luxe/luxury segment. Both traditionally wealthy and new millionaires with aspirational lifestyles are loosening their purse strings," says Piyush Nagda, Director of Private Wealth at Monarch Network Capital. The population of HNWIs rose 10.5 per cent in India to 308,000 in 2021, according to Capgemini's World Wealth Report, which categorises HNWIs as those with investable assets of \$1 million or more, excluding primary residence, collectibles, consumables and consumer durables.

MILLION-DOLLAR HOMES

Meanwhile, the ultra-wealthy are going all out to buy million-dollar homes. According to the Knight Frank India Wealth Report 2022, 29 per cent wealth of the Indian ultra-wealthy (those having a net worth of \$30 million and above) is allocated towards purchase of principal and second homes. As per an India Sotheby's International Realty survey, 67 per cent HNIs plan to buy a luxury home in 2022. "The buyer is getting younger. Historically, we